

AMERICAN SUBMACHINE-GUNS (1920–45)

Originally intended for trench warfare, the submachine-gun achieved notoriety in the US during the “Roaring Twenties” as the weapon of choice for gangsters. Used by criminals such as Clyde Barrow, the Thompson submachine-gun became associated with rum running and violence. During World War II, its usefulness in the field was appreciated by commandoes and infantry facing dogged resistance in all theaters of operation.

▲ THOMPSON M1921

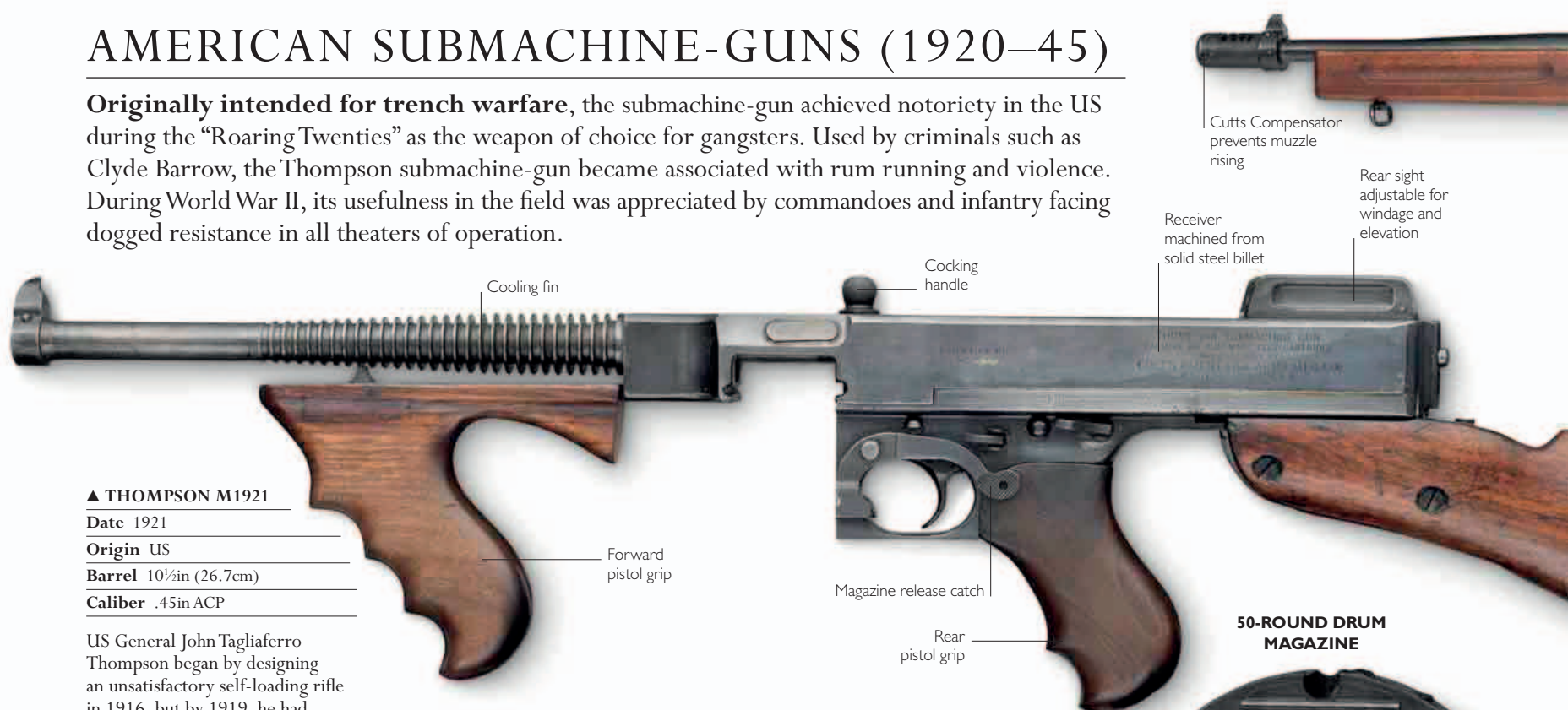
Date 1921

Origin US

Barrel 10½in (26.7cm)

Caliber .45in ACP

US General John Tagliaferro Thompson began by designing an unsatisfactory self-loading rifle in 1916, but by 1919, he had produced an early version of what would be known universally as the Tommy Gun. The M1921 was the first to come to the market, but it was not until 1928 that the US government adopted it, in small numbers, for the Marine Corps.



50-ROUND DRUM MAGAZINE



▲ M3A1

Date 1940s

Origin US

Barrel 8in (20.3cm)

Caliber .45in ACP

The M3 “Grease Gun,” and the improved M3A1 version, were cheap to produce and simple to strip, clean, and maintain. The M3A1 fired the same heavy pistol round used in the Colt M1911A1 (see p. 169).

